

Resource: Tyndale Open Study Notes

Aquifer Open Study Notes (Themes)

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This resource has been adapted into multiple languages, including English, Tok Pisin, Arabic (عربي), French (Français), Hindi (हिंदी), Indonesian (Bahasa Indonesia), Portuguese (Português), Russian (Русский), Spanish (Español), Swahili (Kiswahili), and Simplified Chinese (简体中文).

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“Belief” in the Gospel of John

The theme of “belief” is central in John’s Gospel. John does not use the noun *faith* found often in the New Testament (for example, see [Matthew 8:8-10](#); [Mark 11:22](#); [Acts 20:21](#); [Romans 1:17](#); [3:27-31](#); [4:3-5](#); [Hebrews 11:1-39](#); [James 2:14-24](#); [1 Peter 1:5-7](#)). John prefers the verb form *believe* (“trust” or “be faithful”) to show that faith is not just a fixed belief, but is “alive” and requires action. In John’s Gospel, “believing” in Jesus is the mark of all true disciples.

In the Gospel of John, the verb translated as “believe” is often followed by the Greek preposition *eis*, which means “into.” This combination is unique in ancient Greek usage. For John, belief or faith is not just a status, it is an investment in Jesus. Faith means accepting who Jesus is and who he claims to be.

Faith also involves a commitment to let his invitation to trust in him change how a person lives. Faith is the work God wants from us ([John 6:29](#)). We demonstrate faith by following Jesus’ teachings, loving him, and obeying his commands ([John 8:31](#); [15:1-17](#); see [1 John 5:10](#)).

Passages for Further Study

[Genesis 15:6](#); [Isaiah 28:16](#); [Mark 1:15](#); [Mark 9:23-24](#); [John 1:12-13](#); [John 3:10-18](#); [John 5:24](#); [John 6:35-36](#); [John 7:38](#); [John 9:35-38](#); [John 11:25-27](#); [John 12:37](#); [John 20:25-31](#); [Acts 10:43](#); [Acts 13:39](#); [Romans 1:16](#); [Romans 10:9-10](#); [Hebrews 4:3](#)

“He Will Come”

Jesus promised his followers that he would return to bring them to be with him forever ([John 14:1-3](#)). Right after Jesus ascended to heaven, the apostles received a message that he would come back one day ([Acts 1:9-11](#)). In the visions described in the book of Revelation, John hears Jesus promise to return again ([Revelation 22:6-20](#)).

The final completion of everything, “the Day of the Lord” ([2 Thessalonians 2:2](#)), will come as a surprise, “like a thief in the night” ([1 Thessalonians 5:2](#)). Jesus said “only the Father” knows when that day will be ([Matthew 24:36](#); [Acts 1:6-7](#)). Now is a time for hope and confidence, not guessing. Christians should not set dates and times for the end.

When the Bible teaches about future events (what will happen at the end of time), it gives us two important things: hope during difficult times and wisdom for how to live now. The Bible’s teaching about the end times, also called eschatology (the study of what will happen in the future), helps us focus on living faithfully today. Instead of worrying about exactly when these events will occur, we should concentrate on how we live now.

The apostle Paul describes events like “the rebellion” and the appearance of “the man of lawlessness” that will happen before “the Day of the Lord” ([2 Thessalonians 2:1-12](#)). Yet, he does not focus on the details. Instead, he reminds his audience of these events to refute false teachings and encourage Christians who suffer for the faith ([2 Thessalonians 1:3-10](#); [2:5](#)).

When Christ returns, he will:

- defeat the enemies of the good news about Jesus (the gospel)
- save suffering Christians ([2 Thessalonians 1:7-10](#))
- gather his followers to be with him forever ([1 Thessalonians 4:13-17](#))

This future event requires a response now. Those who accept the good news and live for God can be confident of rescue. Those who reject God will experience eternal destruction. God’s choice and calling of Christians is their hope and comfort ([2 Thessalonians 2:13-14](#)). They can remain steady now as they look to the future ([2:14-15](#)). They have a guarantee of the outcome when he returns.

Passages for Further Study

[Matthew 25:1-46](#); [Acts 1:6-7](#); [1 Thessalonians 4:13-5:11](#); [2 Thessalonians 1:7-10](#); [2 Thessalonians 2:1-12](#)

"I Am" Sayings of Jesus

In the Gospel of John, Jesus often uses the phrase "I am" (in Greek, the phrase is *egō eimi*). Sometimes, Jesus uses this phrase to describe himself. For example, Jesus said, "I am the bread of life." The Gospel of John contains seven statements where Jesus says "I am" followed by a description of himself ([John 6:35](#); [8:12](#); [10:9](#), [11](#); [11:25](#); [14:6](#); [15:1](#)).

It is important to note that Greek does not need the pronoun "I" (*egō*) in these sentences. Therefore, using the pronoun emphasizes the speaker's identity. Another example is in the sermon on the mount in the Gospel of Matthew. Jesus says, "You have heard that it was said ... but I [*egō*] tell you" (see [Matthew 5:22](#), [28](#), [32](#), [34](#), [39](#), [44](#), and other passages). Including the personal pronoun emphasizes the difference between Jesus' teachings and those of Moses. This phrase emphasizes the unique authority of Jesus.

Sometimes, Jesus used the phrase "I am" in a grammatically unusual way, without anything following it. For example, Jesus said, "Before Abraham was even born, I am" ([John 8:58](#)). *Before Abraham, Jesus was what?* (compare [8:28](#), [59](#); [13:19](#)).

The best explanation for this odd expression comes from the Old Testament. When Moses met the Lord on Mount Sinai, he wanted to know God's name ([Exodus 3:6](#), [13-14](#)). God told him that his name is "YHWH," four Hebrew letters that can express existence.

When the Jews translated the Old Testament into Greek, in [Exodus 3:14](#) God's name "I AM WHO I AM" became *egō eimi ho ōn* ("I am the one who is"). In other places, especially in Isaiah [Isaiah 43:25](#); [51:12](#); [52:6](#)), the Greek Old Testament uses *egō eimi* ("I am") as a special way God speaks about himself. In many other verses, the Greek translation uses *kurios* ("Lord") for God's name. Some Jews understood Jesus's words "I am" as a claim to God's name, as in [John 8:58](#), where they tried to stone him. But in other places, like [John 8:24](#), they did not react that way and only asked him, "Who are you?"

Jesus not only represents God. The "I Am" statements show Jesus' divine nature, indicating he can work, speak, and act in place of the Father. He is not just a human. He is the Word of God who became human ([John 1:1](#)). His voice is the Father's voice, and his life reveals God's life in a human body. The phrase "I Am" powerfully expresses who Jesus is.

Passages for Further Study

[John 6:35](#), [48](#); [8:12](#), [58](#); [9:5](#); [10:7-14](#); [11:25](#); [14:6](#); [15:1](#), [5](#)